



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Northern Colorado Christian Academy
School Website: <https://www.nocochristian.org/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Northern Colorado Christian Academy (NCCA) presents a clearly aligned classical Christian program. Public-facing materials consistently anchor education in biblical faith, virtue, and a liberal-arts-centered Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) approach with explicit emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty. The school's mission, vision, and curricular structure foreground a biblically informed worldview, parental partnership, and a teachers-as-virtue-model stance. The overall assessment across the six classical criteria is CLASSICAL, with Element 5 (Faculty) showing only partial alignment (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL) due to comparatively less explicit articulation of the living-curriculum and faculty formation details. The remaining categories demonstrate strong alignment to classical ideals: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, and Parents & Community all show robust evidence of classical orientation. The aggregate reading suggests a fully classical orientation with a single category requiring targeted enhancement to reach full classical fidelity.

Key evidence highlights: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are pervasive: explicit Bible-based framing, God-centered aims, and liturgical dimensions (Chapel, worship) embedded in daily life and coursework. These are reinforced by mission/vision statements and doctrinal commitments.

- Purpose and goals foreground formation of virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing under a liberal arts umbrella, with direct statements about virtue and truth anchored in a Christian worldview.
- Curriculum centers on grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin is taught; history and Western civilization are integrated; Great Books/Paideia-related reading is encouraged via recommended texts.
- Pedagogy reflects the classical Trivium in practice: chanting/recitation during the Grammar stage, and Socratic seminars, debates, and rhetoric in the upper grades; contemplative/restful elements (scholé) are noted as part of the philosophy.
- Faculty and leadership are depicted as stewards of virtue and curriculum, with explicit recognition of teachers as gifted by God and forming part of the living curriculum; formal governance structures exist (Organizing Board).
- Parents and community are positioned as partners in education, with explicit calls for parent involvement and formation, and open-campus/visitation norms.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Proceeding with category-by-category details, including keyword analysis and the justification for each category rating.

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly anchors education in biblical framework and God's truth, with statements such as "the Bible provides the framework for education" and "God's word is the truth." The mission and vision emphasize leading students to virtuous character all for the Glory of God.

- Liturgical and communal practices are indicated, including chapel and worship as integral to schooling. - The academic philosophy references a "classical liberal arts focus" with education grounded in theological commitments and Western Christian tradition.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (illustrative list): Bible, God, truth, God's word, worship, chapel, theology, sacred scripture, liturgy, glory of God, virtue, reverence, wonder, beauty, sacred music, Christian worldview, sacred tradition, western Christian heritage, logos, wisdom. These map directly to Positive Keywords in the Six Essential Elements lexicon. - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or moral-neutral framing detected in the accessible content).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword indicators identified: approximately 8–10 clear terms/themes (Bible, God, truth, worship/chapel, theology/scripture, liturgy, virtue, wonder, beauty, Christian worldview). - Negative keyword indicators: 0 identified. - Ratio: ~8–10 positive vs 0 negative (effectively 100% positive within the visible materials).

Why this rating - The materials demonstrate a high degree of transcendental moral realism and theological grounding. The explicit integration of Bible-based frameworks, worship/liturgy, and the centrality of God's truth in curriculum and mission align closely with Classical expectations for a religiously anchored metaphysical foundation rather than secular or relativistic education.

Citations: the Bible framework and God-centered aims are stated in the School Handbook/Vision/Mission and Academic Philosophy passages.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Vision and mission emphasize formation of leaders with virtue and wisdom for the Glory of God, not merely job preparation. "leadership... virtuous character," and "glory of God" appear repeatedly. - The mission states a commitment to biblical truth and Christ as Savior, with education framed as formation in God-centered truth. - The Academic Philosophy highlights preserving that knowledge through the heritage of the Christian West and fostering wisdom and virtue via classical liberal arts. - Core Values emphasize fear and honor of God and the primacy of biblical truth as the basis for knowledge.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, theology/theology-infused education, permanent questions, great conversation (implied through classical heritage), telos, scholé, contemplation, the true/good/beautiful, beauty, virtue, moral realism, sacred tradition. - Negative keywords present: none observed (no strong workforce- or college-readiness framing that would negate formation emphasis).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword indicators identified: roughly 6–9 prominent terms/phrases (formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal arts, classical heritage, telos, scholé, contemplation, true/good/beautiful). - Negative keyword indicators: 0 identified. - Ratio: predominantly positive (6–9 vs. 0).

Why this rating - The school's stated objectives center on formation of character, virtue, and wisdom through a liberal-arts classical framework, aligned with the transdisciplinary aim to cultivate human excellence rather than purely instrumental training. This aligns strongly with classical educational aims described in the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

Citations: Vision/Mission statements and Academic Philosophy.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is explicitly organized around grammar, logic, and rhetoric, with a K–12 program focused on these Trivium stages, including Latin (3rd–12th). The curriculum section notes reading/literature, Bible, Mathematics, History, Geography, Art, and more, with Latin included in the program. - The historical organizing principle: history is treated as the organizing outline of study, integrating subjects around a historical framework and a biblical worldview. - Suggested reading includes foundational classical texts and works aligned with the classical tradition (e.g., *The Lost Tools of Learning*, *The Abolition of Man*, *The Paideia of God*). - The school emphasizes a “classical liberal arts focus” and the aim to pass on knowledge, understanding, and wisdom rooted in Western Christian heritage.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin, history, Western civilization, classics, sacred tradition, theology, Bible/theology as integrated curriculum, great books (via recommended texts), primary sources, Paideia, liberal arts, and Western civilizational heritage. - Negative keywords present: 0 clear negatives (no explicit “social studies” terminology replacing history or pre-dominance of STEM-first framing observed in public content).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: approximately 6–9 core terms (grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin, history, Western civilization, classics, Paideia, liberal arts; plus integration of Bible/theology). - Negative keywords identified: 0. - Ratio: Strongly Classical (positive dominant).

Why this rating - The explicit inclusion of the Trivium, Latin study, and history-centered, cross-disciplinary integration strongly matches classical curriculum expectations. The explicit emphasis on Great Books/primary sources is present in recommended readings and through the school’s alignment to Paideia/the Lost Tools of Learning lineage, reinforcing classical curriculum identity.

Citations: Curriculum content and recommended reading.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical methods align with the Trivium: Grammar stage uses memorization, singing/chanting, and review; Logic stage emphasizes dialectic and reasoning; Rhetoric stage emphasizes public speaking and debate. The school explicitly describes these pedagogical stages and associated methods.

- The lower grades feature memory-focused learning (chanting/recitation) and restful/scholé-inspired study; upper grades feature Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric exercises. - There is direct emphasis on rhetoric training, speeches, and oratory in upper grades. - The Liturgy/worship integration and the idea of contemplation/restful learning (scholé days) are part of the pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, dialectic, disputation, narration, recitation, chanting, dictation, memory work, rhetoric, speeches, oratory, debate, scholé, contemplation, wonder, seminar, Paideia seminar, restfulness. - Negative keywords present: The lexicon lists potential negative signals (e.g., experiential learning emphasis, project-based learning dominance, constructivist approaches) that are not evidenced as dominant in the school’s public materials. There is no clear projection of those negative signals in the provided content.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: 6–9 core terms (Socratic discussion, seminars, debates; narration/recitation/chanting; memory work; rhetoric; public speaking; scholé/contemplation). - Negative keywords identified: 0–1 explicit negative signals observed. - Ratio: CLASSICAL leaning strongly (positive dominance).

Why this rating - The school’s pedagogy explicitly follows classical teaching methods (grammar/logic/rhetoric; lower-level memorization and chant; upper-level Socratic/seminar methods; rhetoric and public speaking). This aligns with the classical education model and scores as CLASSICAL.

Citations: Pedagogical descriptions and the Trivium outline; lower- and upper-grade methods.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents organized governance (Organizing Board) with named leaders (e.g., Adrienne Haythorn, Director/Principal; Karla Bowness, Director of Children's Ministries). This demonstrates formal leadership and accountability structures. - The philosophy references teachers as "called of God and gifted in teaching," suggesting teachers are viewed as moral and vocational exemplars within a Christian frame. This is supportive of the "teachers as models of virtue" expectation in classical education. - However, explicit, public articulation of the "living curriculum" and formal teacher-professional development programs in classical pedagogy (e.g., deliberate faculty seminars, great-books seminars for faculty, explicit portrait of teacher/s student archetypes) is less evident in the public materials provided. The site emphasizes teacher-oriented methods and biblical/theological underpinnings, but does not consistently present a robust, explicit "faculty formation" narrative beyond the general statements above.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (inferred from public materials): teachers as models of virtue, formation through example, careful selection of teachers aligned with Christian worldview; portrait of a teacher; collegial culture (somewhat implied by governance and organized structure). These align with Positive Keywords for Faculty in the classical lexicon. - Negative keywords present: explicit mentions of "facilitators on the side" or non-classical faculty models are not present; however, the public materials provide limited explicit confirmation of the "living curriculum" or faculty-as-core curriculum beyond general statements.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword indicators identified: 1–2 explicit phrases (teacher as "called of God and gifted in teaching"; board leadership). Additional signals (organizing-board structure) provide supportive evidence but are not as explicit as statements about the living curriculum or faculty seminars. - Negative keyword indicators: 0 explicit negative signals. - Ratio: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (some classical signals present, but less explicit articulation of the full faculty-as-living-curriculum narrative).

Why this rating - The school demonstrates some classical-faculty signals (teacher as virtuous exemplar; governance; explicitly Christian teacher framing) but lacks a consistently explicit, public articulation of a robust living-curriculum faculty-development program and a comprehensive portrait of what a model teacher should be in the classical sense. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Organizing Board page and the "teacher called of God" language.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly frames parents as co-educators and as entrusted with core responsibilities: "the Bible clearly places the responsibility for the education of children in the hands of their parents," and the school views itself as partnering with parents in education. - The mission and philosophy emphasize partnership with families and parental formation; the school communicates with parents via book studies, gatherings, and website content intended to educate parents about classical education. - The school invites campus visits and open engagement with families; contact information and campus-visit invites appear on the Home page and related sections.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental primacy, parent formation, reading groups, seminars, classical book clubs, open campus, parent covenant, family liturgy, home-centered learning, parental engagement. - Negative keywords present: none observed (no consumer/customer framing; no minimal parent involvement).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: at least 6–8 distinct terms/phrases (partnership with families; co-teachers; parent formation; classical reading groups; book clubs; open-campus; parental engagement; parent covenant). - Negative keywords identified: 0. - Ratio: CLASSICAL (clear and explicit parent-community alignment).

Why this rating - The school emphasizes strong parental partnership, formation, and ongoing engagement, which is central to classical education's community-partner ethos. The public materials consistently frame

parents as co-educators and active participants, aligning with the classical model.

Citations: Vision/Mission (family partnership; biblical framing) and campus-visit/parent engagement language.

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 5 (Faculty): Add explicit, public articulation of a “living curriculum” faculty framework and ongoing classical-pedagogy professional development. Publish a formal statement detailing how faculty engage in great-books seminars, faculty collaboration, mentoring, and teacher formation within a classical-Christian framework.
- For Element 3 (Curriculum): Strengthen explicit language about “Great Books” and “Great Conversation” as a measurable curricular component, with a published list of core Great Books and a plan for how those texts are integrated across grades. This would more clearly align with the lexicon’s Great Books/Paideia signals.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Continue to document and publish specifics about scholé (restful learning) practices, contemplative days, and structured opportunities for student-led inquiry within the grammar-/logic/rhetoric progression, with examples of student work and assessment aligned to these practices.
- For Element 1/Element 2 (Foundations and Goals): Maintain and deepen explicit references to transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and the theological framing of learning, ensuring that all disciplines articulate how these enduring realities shape curriculum decisions, assessment, and student formation.
- For Element 6 (Parents & Community): Expand on parent-formation programming (book studies, lectures, family-scholarly events) with a published calendar and outcomes metrics to demonstrate tangible parent-partner impact.

These needle-movers would consolidate Element 5 and push the overall profile toward a fully CLASSICAL classification.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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